SAMPLE

Famous Astronomers: Reinhard Genzel

Proving the Black Hole at the Galactic Center

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Free sample: Introduction & Chapter 1

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Introduction

The center of the Milky Way is twenty-six thousand light-years away, hidden behind the dust of the galactic plane, and for most of the twentieth century it was a place astronomers could argue about but not see. Reinhard Genzel is the man who saw it anyway. He did not see it with his eyes, since the dust forbids visible light entirely, and he did not see it with a single instrument, since no one instrument was equal to the job. He saw it by spending forty years teaching machines to watch, first a Chilean telescope taught to freeze the blur of the atmosphere, then a suite of European instruments taught to correct the blur in real time, and finally an interferometer taught to combine four giant telescopes into one. What the machines recorded, once they could record cleanly, was the plainest and strangest sight in modern astronomy: stars, dozens of them, whipping around a patch of empty sky at thousands of kilometers per second, orbiting nothing anyone could photograph. The nothing, when the orbits were added up, weighed four point three million times what the Sun weighs, packed inside a space the planetary orbits would rattle around in. There is exactly one object in physics that can be that heavy and that small and that dark, and Genzel's patience is the reason a whole generation of scientists stopped saying black hole cautiously and started saying it plainly.

He was born in 1952 in Bad Homburg, a spa town near Frankfurt, the son of a solid-state physicist, and the household gave him both the habit of instruments and the conviction that the hardest problems are attacked with tools you build yourself. He took his doctorate in radio astronomy at Freiburg and Bonn in 1978, crossed to Harvard as a Miller Fellow, and held a Berkeley professorship while still in his twenties. In 1986 he moved to Garching, outside Munich, to direct the Max Planck Institute for Extraterrestrial Physics, and from that institute, with a changing cast of students and instruments over four decades, he ran the longest observation campaign in the history of astronomy: the siege of the galactic center, conducted with infrared light, one star at a time, until the stars confessed what they were circling.

The confession arrived in stages. Gas motions measured with Charles Townes, the laser's own inventor, in the 1980s pointed to a dark mass of millions of Suns. The first stellar orbits, traced with speckle imaging in the 1990s, tightened the case. The full sixteen-year orbit of the star called S2, closed in the 2000s, removed the reasonable doubt. The relativistic wobble in that same star's orbit, measured with the GRAVITY instrument in 2020, settled the matter beyond appeal. And in October of that same year the Nobel committee split the physics prize three ways, giving Roger Penrose half for the theory that black holes must exist and giving the other half jointly to Genzel and Andrea Ghez, the two leaders of the rival teams that showed one actually does, at the center of our own galaxy.

A word on how this volume is built, before the chapters begin, since the reader deserves to know the footing. The chapters run in the series' fixed order, beginning with his life and moving through the physics he used, the instruments he built, the era he worked in, the sources that document him, and the meaning of the whole campaign. The evidence beneath every claim is the public record, his papers and lectures and interviews, the Nobel citations, and the observation logs of a campaign he has described as thirty years of stubbornness. The signature he left on the sky is not a portrait but a ledger of orbits, and this biography is built the way he built his evidence, by returning to the same points again and again until they hold.

There is also a warning the introduction owes the reader, the ordinary one that a series of astronomer biographies repeats at its front doors, that the books are written from the public record and that the reader checking any claim will find the trail. In Genzel's case the trail is unusually short, since the man is living, the group is publishing, and the papers, lectures, and interviews of the last forty years are one search away. The biography you are holding is therefore not an archaeology but a portrait of a career still in progress, and the honest way to read it is the way the man reads his own star field, with attention, patience, and a willingness to be corrected by the next data point. The center holds, the instruments improve, and the account that follows is the story of how one human stubbornness was matched against one galactic fact until the fact gave up and told the truth. A last orientation helps before the door opens on the life, since the reader should know what kind of chapters are coming. The volume walks the series' fixed road, the life first, then the physics, then the instruments, the era, the record, the meaning, and it walks the road at the pace of a biography rather than a textbook, which means every technical fact arrives attached to a year, a mountain, or a machine, and the reader who dislikes equations can read the whole account without meeting one. The road was built for young readers and patient adults alike, it is the same road every volume in this series walks, and the walker who finishes it will know not only what one astronomer found but how a fact of this size is actually found, assembled, defended, and finally awarded.

Chapter 1: The Discovery of Reinhard Genzel

Every scientist is discovered twice, once by the world and once by the work, and in Genzel's case the first discovery happened in a German household where physics was the family trade. Ludwig Genzel, his father, taught solid-state physics at professorial rank, and the son grew up around laboratories, around the talk of crystals and detectors, around the conviction that nature is questioned with apparatus. Reinhard Genzel was born on March 12, 1952, in Bad Homburg, the hillside spa town above Frankfurt, and the postwar Germany of his childhood was rebuilding its scientific institutions at the same time it was rebuilding its cities, so a boy inclined to physics found a country taking the subject seriously again.

His own inclination ran to the sky. He studied at Freiburg and then at Bonn, and his doctoral work, finished in 1978, was done at the Max Planck Institute for Radio Astronomy, where the instruments listened to the universe in centimeter waves. The training mattered more than the subject matter, since radio astronomy is interferometry, the art of combining separated telescopes into one instrument of impossible sharpness, and the young doctor learned early that the frontier of astronomy is often the frontier of instrumentation. Everything he did afterward, the speckle work, the adaptive optics, the interferometer called GRAVITY, is interferometry in one costume or another.

The world then took a hand. He went to the United States as a Miller Fellow at Berkeley, working in the orbit of the Harvard-Smithsonian Center for Astrophysics; the American years gave him two things he kept for life. The first was a taste for big questions asked in plain terms, the California style, and the second was a mentor unlike any other: Charles Hard Townes, who had given the world the maser and then the laser and taken the Nobel for it, and who by the 1980s wanted to know about the center of the galaxy. Townes had calculated that the infrared was the way in, since dust that defeats visible light passes infrared freely, and he wanted to point spectrometers at the galactic center and read the gas. The young German and the older American measured together, and the measurements showed gas near the center moving at speeds no star cluster could sustain, the first whispers of the dark mass.

He returned to Germany in 1981 with a Berkeley professorship in hand, splitting his years between two hemispheres, and in 1986 he made the move that defined the rest of the story, taking the directorship of the Max Planck Institute for Extraterrestrial Physics in Garching. The institute had been built for space research and X-ray astronomy, and Genzel aimed a share of its whole apparatus at one target. He has directed the institute for nearly four decades while holding a part-time Berkeley appointment from 1999 to 2016, an honorary professorship at the Ludwig Maximilian University of Munich since 1988, and the leadership of a research family whose former students now direct observatories and institutes around the globe.

The discovery of Genzel by his own work, the second discovery, came slowly, which is the point. In the early 1990s his group went to the New Technology Telescope in Chile and used a technique called speckle imaging, which takes hundreds of short exposures and reconstructs what the atmosphere blurred, to pick out individual stars at the galactic center for the first time. The stars moved. Year by year the group measured the movements, and by the millennium's turn the tracks bent around a single point, and the point was empty. The world's astronomers, looking over his shoulder at those tracks, met the man the sky had been introducing for twenty years: a patient instrument-builder who had decided, before almost anyone else, that the galactic center was worth a lifetime. The discovery chapter should end, though, by refusing a comfortable myth, the one that casts him as the lone hunter of the hidden monster, because the record shows something better than a myth. What the record shows is an organizer, a man whose rarest gift was not the idea of watching the center, which several people had, but the ability to hold a forty-year supply line open to a target nobody could promise would ever confess. The lifetime that closed around S2's first orbit was not spent at a telescope eyepiece, since infrared astronomy has no eyepieces, but in offices, committee rooms, and design reviews, and the ordinariness of the setting is the last fact this chapter wants to leave with the reader: the greatest patrol of the galaxy's center was conducted, mostly, in meetings, by a man who never stopped believing they were worth holding. The life also contains a quieter chapter the record mentions but the headlines skipped, the years of administration and mentorship that a Max Planck directorship is made of, and the reader should file them as part of the discovery rather than as overhead. The hiring decisions built the group, the committee work kept the telescope time flowing, the design reviews kept the instruments honest, and a fraction of every one of those hours ended up inside the error bars of the final mass. Biography usually awards its attention to the moments of public triumph, and this one has had its share, but the truer portrait is the calendar, a working life of which the Nobel evening was exactly one row. The row should be described once, since the reader deserves the scene. October 2020 found the prizewinner informed by phone in the middle of a working day in Germany, in a year when the ceremonies were held remotely, and the photographs

the news services ran were of a man at a desk, in a pandemic-empty institute, taking a call about the physics of the galaxy's center. Of all the images the campaign produced, star trails, orbit diagrams, flare light curves, the one history may keep is that quiet desk, since it is the truest portrait of how the discovery was actually made, decades at a time, in an ordinary room.